

Sukumar Sen (1898–1963), was a civil servant tasked with organizing India’s first general election in 1952. He was the first Chief Election Commissioner, and set up many of the electoral processes and infrastructure India still relies on.

When India became an independent nation, the majority of its population was poor and illiterate. The government had to work hard and fast to set up organizations and institutions that would oversee key functions and kickstart development. Strong institutions, especially in education, science and technology, would be the foundations upon which a modern nation could be built. One of the biggest challenges that the leaders of new India faced was that many things had to be figured out from scratch, from how to conduct elections, to how to measure and use the country’s